TEXORA · SESSIONAL NOTES · LAB EXPERIMENT SHEET

Communication Software

The software layer that carries a textile factory's words and numbers — email, messaging, shared files and the factory network underneath them — set up, organised and used the way a production office actually works.

TE-3208 · SOFTWARE AND AI IN TEXTILE MANUFACTURING SESSIONAL · EXPERIMENT 1 · LEVEL 3 TERM 2

1. Aim

To map the communication software used in a textile factory, set up a professional email account structure for a production office, organise shared documents on a local network, and carry out a complete buyer-communication cycle — enquiry, quotation file transfer and order confirmation — using the correct tool at each step.

2. Concepts you need

- **Communication software** is any program whose main job is moving information between people or systems: email clients, instant-messaging and group-chat tools, video-conferencing software, shared file storage, and the internal systems (ERP/MIS screens) through which departments exchange production data.
- **Email** remains the formal channel of the export textile trade. A buyer's purchase order, a lab-dip approval and a shipment advice are contractual documents; they travel by email because email is addressed, dated, archived and searchable. Chat messages are fast but are not the record.
- **LAN, server and shared folders:** inside the factory, computers connect over a Local Area Network. A central **server** holds shared folders (e.g. *Production*, *Merchandising*, *QC*) so that one file — the current order sheet — exists once, instead of as ten conflicting copies on ten desks.
- **Synchronous vs asynchronous:** video calls and chat are synchronous (both sides present, immediate); email and shared documents are asynchronous (read and answered when convenient, across time zones — essential when the buyer is six hours behind).
- **File discipline:** a communication is only as good as its attachment. File naming (*OrderNo_DocType_Date*), version numbers and size limits decide whether the receiver can use what you sent. Large artwork and tech-pack files go through shared links, not as email attachments.

- **Security basics:** business email compromise — a fake "buyer" message changing bank details — is a real fraud pattern in the garment trade. Verify changed payment instructions through a second channel, use strong passwords with two-factor authentication, and never open unexpected attachments.

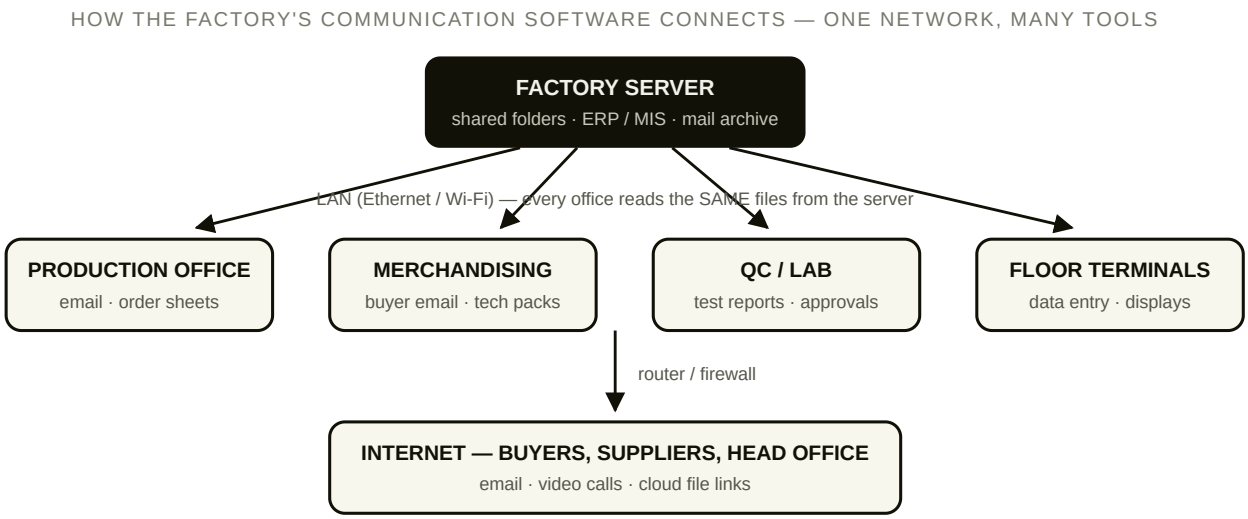


Figure 1 — A typical factory communication layout. Internal traffic stays on the LAN and the shared server; only buyer- and supplier-facing traffic crosses the internet boundary.

3. Lab procedure

1. List the communication software available in the lab (email client/webmail, chat, video, shared drive). For each, note whether it is synchronous or asynchronous and one factory task it suits.
2. Create the folder structure of a merchandising shared drive: *BuyerName / OrderNo /* with subfolders *TechPack*, *Approvals*, *Correspondence*, *Shipment*.
3. Compose the enquiry-acknowledgement email of the worked example: correct subject line, named attachment, professional signature block (name, designation, department, phone).
4. Send the tech-pack file by shared link instead of attachment; set the link to view-only and note why edit access is not given.
5. Hold a 10-minute video call with another lab group acting as the buyer: confirm the order verbally, then send the written confirmation email within the hour — the call agrees, the email records.
6. File every message of the exercise under the order folder, following the naming rule *OrderNo_DocType_Date*.

4. Worked example — one order's communication cycle

A buyer emails an enquiry for 12,000 pcs of a basic T-shirt. The complete cycle, with the right tool at each step:

STEP	TOOL	WHAT IS SENT / DONE
1. Enquiry received	Email	Buyer's enquiry with tech pack (PDF, 4 MB) arrives at merchandising@factory — a departmental address, so the message survives any one person's absence.
2. Acknowledgement	Email	Subject: *Re: Enquiry — 12,000 pcs Basic Tee, Style BT-220 — Ref ORD-2026-118*. Body confirms receipt, names the merchandiser responsible, promises costing by a stated date.
3. Costing file	Shared folder + link	Costing sheet saved once on the server as *ORD-2026-118_Costing_v2_2026-03-04*; production and merchandising read the same version. The buyer receives only the quotation summary.
4. Clarification	Video call + email	A call settles the GSM tolerance question in minutes; the agreed tolerance is then written into a confirmation email — the record of the call.
5. Order confirmation	Email	Purchase order received, checked against the quotation, and confirmed by return email with order number, quantity, price and delivery date restated.

The data-volume point: the floor terminals of one weaving shed report production every minute of a 480-minute shift. For 40 machines that is 40 × 480 = **19,200 records per shift** — far too many to move by hand or by chat message. Communication software earns its place precisely where volume, distance or the need for a written record rules out walking over and talking.

5. Practice tasks

1. A buyer changes the delivery bank account by an email from a new address one day before payment. State the correct response procedure, step by step.
2. An artwork file of 60 MB must reach the buyer. The office email limit is 20 MB per message. State the correct method and the two settings you apply to it.
3. Draft the subject line and file name for: the lab-dip approval message of order ORD-2026-121, sent 14 March 2026, second submission.

Answer key

1. Do **not** act on the email alone. (i) Stop the payment change. (ii) Contact the buyer through an already-known channel — the phone number or address from earlier correspondence, not one given in the suspicious message — and confirm verbally. (iii) Inform accounts and management; changed bank details are a classic business-email-compromise fraud. Only a confirmation through the independent channel authorises the change.
2. Send it through the shared file service (cloud drive) as a **link in the email body**, not as an attachment. Settings: **view-only** permission (the buyer can download/print but not alter the master file) and, where the system allows, an **expiry date** on the link. The master file stays in the order's *Approvals* folder under the naming rule.
3. Subject: *Lab Dip Approval — ORD-2026-121 — Submission 2*. File name: *ORD-2026-121_LabDip_v2_2026-03-14* — order number first (so folders sort by order), document type, version, ISO date. Both make the message findable in seconds, months later, by someone who did not send it.
